



Maritime &
Coastguard
Agency

MARINE INFORMATION NOTE

MIN 720 (M)

Transforming Seafarer Training: The UK's Modernised Officer Qualifications Syllabus

Notice to all Shipowners, Operators, Masters, Skippers, Officers, Cadets, and those concerned with maritime training.

This notice should be read with MSN 1856 Amendment 1, MSN 1857 Amendment 1 and MSN 1860 Amendment 1.

This MIN expires 30 April 2028.

Summary

This MIN sets out the changes to the UK's seafarer officer qualifications syllabus, overseen by the Maritime and Coastguard Agency (MCA) through the Cadet Training & Modernisation (CT&M) Programme. Established in late 2021, the CT&M Programme aims to implement recommendations from the Maritime Skills Commission's (MSC) Seafarer Cadet Review, bringing together experts from various organisations to modernise and improve training. This collaborative effort has resulted in an updated syllabus for Nautical, Engineering, and Electro-Technical disciplines, set to be implemented by UK/MCA Approved Nautical Colleges/Universities from August/September 2025. Additionally, it outlines the modernisation of MCA assessments, which are planned to replace existing written exams.

1. Introduction/background

- 1.1 The UK's seafarer officer qualifications syllabus has undergone its first major overhaul in many years, overseen by the Maritime and Coastguard Agency (MCA) through the Cadet Training & Modernisation (CT&M) Programme.
- 1.2 The CT&M Programme was established in late 2021 to implement the recommendations from the Maritime Skills Commission's Seafarer Cadet Review. It

brings together approximately 41 people from 24 organisations, dedicating their expertise to modernise and improve Merchant Navy Cadet and Officer training.

- 1.3 One of the key achievements has been the completion of the Cadet Syllabus Review. The syllabuses for Nautical, Engineering, and Electro-Technical disciplines have been updated to reflect current practices and technology used on board. While the MCA led on the programme modernisation project, it was industry driven in determining the skills needed for the updated syllabuses.

This marks the important collaboration between a maritime regulator, seafarers and industry experts to shape training, with aims of influencing global standards through the International Maritime Organization (IMO). The new syllabuses, which go beyond the minimum criteria required by the STCW Convention, are set to be implemented by UK/MCA Approved Nautical Colleges/Universities from August 2025, include updated content on current practices, technology, cyber security, and 'human element' skills to enhance seafarer wellbeing and operational safety. Additionally, the syllabuses incorporate training on alternative fuels and new technologies associated with decarbonisation.

- 1.4 Nautical Colleges have played a crucial role in this transformation. They have worked diligently to integrate the updated syllabuses and prepare for the new qualifications. This collaborative approach with industry stakeholders has ensured that the syllabuses are comprehensive, modern, and relevant, positioning cadets and officers for success in the maritime industry.
- 1.5 This MIN confirms the changes and provides a new timeline for the programme start date, new assessments and transitional arrangements for those currently in the system.

2. Deck Qualifications

- 2.1 All qualifications listed in this section must have been completed at an MCA-Approved College as part of an MCA-Approved Deck cadetship programme, as per Annex G of [MSN 1856 \(Amendment 1\)](#). This section only focuses on the following requirements from [MSN 1856 \(Amendment 1\)](#):

- The approved education and training programme meeting the standards of competency specified in section A-II/1 and A-II/2 of the STCW Code as listed in section 11 of the MSN.
- Navigation and Stability assessment requirements

All other requirements in [MSN 1856 \(Amendment 1\)](#) must be met prior to the issuance of the corresponding CoC.

2.2 Summary of Deck Changes

This section aims to provide a quick overview of the upcoming changes:

- 2.3 From August 2025: all new Deck OOW course starters will follow a revised syllabus and must pass new MCA assessments for Navigation and Stability.

Chief Mate Progression:

- Those who hold a Management Level academic qualification progressing to a Chief Mate Unlimited CoC: From March 2026, candidates can undertake the new MCA assessments for Chief Mate Navigation and Stability*.
- Those who hold an Operational Level academic qualification progressing to a Chief Mate unlimited CoC: From August 2026, candidates must complete the new Chief Mate syllabus for their top-up qualification. However, this qualification may be available from September 2025, so check with your college. From October 2026 they must also pass the Chief Mate MCA assessments for Management Level Navigation and Stability.

Exemptions: Those enrolled on an MCA approved OOW Foundation Degree or Degree qualification before August 2025, will continue to be exempt from the OOW MCA assessments for Navigation and Stability until September 2029.

**Alternatively, until April 2028, they may complete the SQA Written Examinations for Navigation and Stability at the college's discretion. See table in section 2.6.*

2.4 OOW and Chief Mate Qualifications (Operational and Management Level)

From August 2025, all OOW candidates will follow the updated MCA syllabus, which aims to ensure that seafarers are equipped with the necessary skills and competencies to safely operate vessels. In addition, the new syllabus will help develop skills that make candidates more attractive for employment by providing the latest skills needed to operate ships and preparing them for newer technologies.

Regardless of the route followed, candidates who start from or after August 2025 will need to complete the new MCA Navigation and Stability assessments for Operational Level Navigation and Stability. When progressing to the Chief Mate Unlimited CoC, candidates will need to complete the new Management Level assessments. These assessments have been modernised and aligned with the new syllabus. While they will replace the existing written exams, they will continue to focus on core competency requirements of Navigation and Stability, incorporating modern methods of assessment.

The new assessment format will be available from March 2026, and depending on the programme, assessments will take place accordingly.

The specific timeline for each Deck OOW route is detailed in Annex A.

2.5 Chief Mate Top Up Qualifications

From September 2026, those who hold an Officer of the Watch (OOW) Certificate but still need to complete the educational programme for a Chief Mate (Unlimited) CoC, commonly referred to as HND/Dip HE/Advanced Diploma 'top up', will be required to follow the modernised Chief Mate syllabus. This route is for those who are only qualified at the Operational Level, usually by obtaining an HNC/Cert HE/Advanced Certificate qualification. **However, the new modernised Chief Mate route may be available at some Colleges from September 2025**, please speak to the college where you are applying, to ensure you are aware of the requirements.

If you undertake this route from September 2026, you will be required to complete the new modernised MCA safety assessments for Chief Mate. These assessments have been aligned with the new syllabus. While they will replace traditional written exams, they will continue to focus on core competency requirements of Navigation and Stability whilst incorporating modern methods of assessment.

Those currently in the system, completing or having completed the full Management Level qualification, such as SPD, HND, Dip HE, Advanced Diploma, Foundation Degree, or Honours Degree, should refer to section 2.6 in this MIN.

The new assessment format will be available from March 2026, and depending on the programme, assessments will take place accordingly.

The specific timeline for each Deck 'Chief Mate Top Up' route is detailed in Annex A.

2.6 Those currently in the system

Seafarers currently in the system working towards either an OOW and/or Chief Mate qualification will continue on the same programme. However, from March 2026, those who have completed their qualification, or those who are still undertaking their qualification but are ready to undertake an MCA Assessments, will have the option of either undertaking the current written examinations administered by the SQA or the modernised MCA assessments for Navigation and Stability. The table below in this section summarises the availability of this choice. All MCA written exams administered by SQA in their current format will cease from April 2028.

Those who have been enrolled on the Deck SPD, Foundation Degree or Degree level qualification before August 2025, will still be eligible for an exemption from the Operational Level Navigation and Stability assessments up until September 2029.

	Discretion of college/candidate		
	SQA Written Exam	SQA Written or New MCA Assessment	New MCA Assessment
HNC/HND - OOW Candidates who started before 2025	Now to March 2026	March 2026 to March/April 2028	April 2028 onwards
FD OOW Candidates who started before 2025	SQA Written Exam	SQA Written or New MCA Assessment	New MCA Assessment
	N/A	N/A	April 2028 onwards
Chief Mate Candidates who started before 2025	SQA Written Exam	SQA Written or New MCA Assessment	New MCA Assessment
	Now to March 2026	March 2026 to March/April 2028	April 2028 onwards

3. Engineering

3.1 All qualifications listed in this section must have been completed at an MCA-approved college as part of an MCA-approved engineering programme, as per Annex D of [MSN 1857 \(Amendment 1\)](#). This section only focuses on the following requirements from [MSN 1857 \(Amendment 1\)](#):

- The approved education and training programme meeting the standards of competency specified in section A-III/1 and A-III/2 of the STCW Code as listed in section 7 of the MSN.
- The Engineering Knowledge assessment requirements

All other requirements in [MSN 1857 \(Amendment 1\)](#) must be met prior to the issuance of the corresponding CoC.

3.2 Summary of Engineering Changes

This section aims to provide a quick overview of the upcoming changes:

- From August 2025: all new EOW Cadet starters will follow a revised syllabus and must pass new MCA assessment for Operational level Engineering Knowledge.

Second Engineer Progression:

- Those who hold a Management level academic Qualification progressing to a Second Engineer Unlimited CoC: From October 2026, can undertake the new MCA assessments for Management Level Engineering Knowledge*,
- Those who hold an Operational Level academic qualification progressing to a Second Engineer Unlimited CoC: from September 2026, must complete the new Second Engineer syllabus for their top-up qualification. This qualification may be available from September 2025, so check with your college. From October 2026 they must also pass the new MCA assessment for Management level Engineering Knowledge.

Exemptions: Those enrolled on an MCA approved Foundation Degree or Degree in Marine Engineering before August 2025, are exempt from the Operational level MCA assessments for Engineering Knowledge until September 2029.

**Alternatively, up until April 2028, they may complete the SQA Written Examinations for Engineering Knowledge at the college's discretion.*

- Those using the alternative route, enrolling up until July 2026, may continue to use the existing routes. For experienced seafarers please refer to [MSN 1857 \(Amendment 1\)](#) and graduate/alternative/fast-track route please refer [MIN 511 \(Amendment 1\)](#). The required modules and examinations will be available until April 2028. After this date, they must complete the corresponding modernised modules and assessments for the CoC required. From August 2026, colleges and universities will start issuing action plans based against the new modernised syllabus.

3.3 EOW and Second Engineering Qualifications (Operational and Management Level)

Starting from August 2025, all Engineer Officer of the Watch (EOW) cadetships (not experienced seafarers or graduate routes) will follow the updated MCA syllabus. This updated syllabus aims to ensure that seafarers are equipped with the necessary skills and competencies to safely maintain and operate vessels. Additionally, the new syllabus will help develop skills that make candidates more attractive for employment by providing the latest skills needed to maintain and operate ships and preparing them for newer technologies.

Cadets starting from August 2025 will need to complete the new Operational level Engineering Knowledge assessments for the EOW CoC. When progressing to the Second Engineer Unlimited CoC, candidates will need to complete the new Management level assessments. These assessments have been modernised and aligned with the new syllabus. While they will replace the traditional written exams, they will continue to focus on core competency requirements of critical engineering knowledge and its application, incorporating modern methods of assessment.

The new assessment format will be available from March 2026, and depending on the programme, assessments will take place accordingly.

The specific timeline for each EOOW Cadet route is detailed in Annex B.

3.4 Second Engineering Top Up Qualifications

From September 2026, those who completed EOOW CoC Certificate but still need to complete the educational programme for a Second Engineer CoC, will be required to follow the updated Second Engineer syllabus. This route is for those who are only qualified at the Operational level, usually by obtaining an HNC/Cert HE/Advanced Certificate qualification or who undertook the Experienced Seafarer Route.

Up until this date, Colleges can continue to offer the Second Engineer Management Level academic examinations route (Mathematics, Engineering Drawing, Applied Mechanics, Applied Heat, Electrotechnology, and Naval Architecture), and the candidate will also still need to complete the existing Management level Engineering Knowledge examinations.

However, the new modernised Second Engineering route may be available at some colleges from September 2025, please speak to the college where you are applying, to ensure you are aware of the requirements.

Those eligible for this new route will not need to complete the academic examinations (Mathematics, Engineering Drawing, Applied Mechanics, Applied Heat, Electrotechnology, and Naval Architecture). Instead, they will need to complete the corresponding modules and assessments at the MCA-Approved Nautical College.

From October 2026, you will be able to take the new modernised assessment that will replace the existing Management level written exams. These assessments will continue to focus on core competency requirements of critical engineering knowledge and its application, incorporating modern methods of assessment. Up until October 2026, you will need to complete the current Management level Engineering Knowledge examinations. The table in section 3.5 summarises the availability of this choice.

3.5 Those Currently in the System

Seafarers currently in the system working towards either an EOOW and/or Second Engineer qualification will continue on the same programme. Noting that:

- From March 2026, those who have completed their academic qualification and are looking to obtain an EOOW CoC will have the option of either undertaking the current Operational Engineering Knowledge Exams administered by IAMI or the modernised MCA assessments.
- From October 2026, those who have completed their academic qualification and are looking to obtain a Second Engineer CoC will have the option of either undertaking the current Management level Engineering Knowledge Exams administered by the SQA or the modernised MCA assessments.

The table below in this section summarises the availability of this choice. All MCA written exams administered by IAMI or SQA in their current format will cease from April 2028, to be replaced by the modernised assessments.

Those who have completed the EOOW Foundation Degree or Degree level qualification will still be eligible for an exemption from the EOOW Engineering Knowledge Exams.

		Discretion of College/Candidate	
HNC/HND – EOOW Candidates who started before 2025	IAMI Written Exam	IAMI Written or New MCA Assessment	New MCA Assessment
	Now to March 2026	March 2026 to March/April 2028	April 2028 onwards
FD EOOW Candidates who started before 2025	IAMI Written Exam	IAMI Written or New MCA Assessment	New MCA Assessment
	N/A	N/A	April 2028 onwards
Second Engineer Candidates started before 01 October 2027 will have the option	SQA Written Exam	SQA Written or New MCA Assessment	New MCA Assessment
	Now to March/April 2028	October 2027 to March/April 2028	April 2028 onwards

3.6 Graduate Route and Experienced Seafarer Route to EOOW

Those entering the system up until July 2026 may continue to utilise the existing routes:

- Experienced Seafarers [MSN 1857 \(Amendment 1\)](#) section 7.6
- Graduate/Alternative/Fast-track Route [MIN 511 \(Amendment 1\)](#)

The modules and/or examinations they are required to complete will remain available until April 2028. After this date, they will need to complete the corresponding modules and assessments for the CoC required from the new Operational or Management level qualification. They should speak to the college they are attending or plan to attend for further details.

As per section 3.5, in addition to any academic requirements, candidates will still need to complete MCA Engineering assessments:

- From March 2026, those who have completed their qualification and are looking to obtain an EOOW CoC will have the option of either undertaking the current Engineering Knowledge Exams administered by IAMI or the modernised MCA assessments.
- From October 2026, those who have completed their qualification and are looking to obtain a Second Engineer CoC will have the option of either undertaking the current Engineering Knowledge Exams administered by the SQA or the modernised MCA assessments.

All MCA written exams administered by IAMI/SQA will cease from April 2028, to be replaced by the modernised assessments.

Experienced seafarers entering the system from August 2026, will undertake the new modernised route, which will see them working towards a recognised HNC/Cert HE/National Diploma as the qualification required for the underpinning knowledge of an EOOW CoC. Exemptions from modules and assessments will be available in line with the process set out in [MSN 1857 \(Amendment 1\)](#) section 3.

Those eligible to enter the alternate routes (e.g. Graduates or those that have completed 'Higher or Degree' Apprenticeships) entering the system from August 2026, will be issued a new action plan setting out the new modules and/or assessments they need to complete to fulfil the education and training requirements for the underpinning knowledge required for the issuance of a CoC.

The specific timeline for the Engineering Alternative Routes is detailed in Annex C.

4. Electro-Technical Officers (ETOs)

4.1 All qualifications listed in this section must have been completed at an MCA-approved college as part of an MCA-approved ETO programme, as per Annex B of [MSN 1860 \(Amendment 1\)](#). This section only focuses on the following requirement from [MSN 1860 \(Amendment 1\)](#):

- The approved education and training programme meeting the standards of competency specified in section A-III/6 of the STCW Code as listed in section 8 of the MSN.

All other requirements in [MSN 1860 \(Amendment 1\)](#) must be met prior to the issuance of the corresponding CoC.

4.2 Summary of ETO Changes

This section aims to provide a quick overview of the upcoming changes:

- From August 2025, all new ETO Cadet course starters will follow a revised syllabus. New entrants from this date will also be required to undertake a new Operational Electrical Knowledge assessment.
- A separate MIN will be produced outlining the Alternative Routes for Experienced Seafarers, Graduates, 'Higher and Degree' Apprenticeships, and Apprenticeships with appropriate industrial experience.

4.3 ETO Qualifications

Starting from August 2025, all ETO Cadetships (not experienced seafarers or graduate/apprenticeship routes) will follow the updated MCA syllabus. This update aims to ensure that seafarers are equipped with the necessary skills and competencies to safely maintain and operate vessels. Additionally, the new syllabus will help develop skills that make candidates more attractive for employment by providing the latest skills needed to maintain and operate ships and preparing them for newer technologies.

Regardless of the route followed, Cadets who start from or after August 2025 will need to complete the new Operational Electrical Knowledge assessment for the ETO CoC.

The specific timeline for each ETO route is detailed in Annex D.

4.4 Graduate Route and Experienced Seafarer Route to ETO

Those entering the system up until July 2026, will continue to utilise the existing routes set out in [MSN 1860 \(Amendment 1\)](#). Regardless of the route followed, candidates who start from or after September 2025 will need to complete the new Operational Electrical Knowledge assessment for the ETO CoC, which will be available from October 2026.

A new MIN will be published outlining new proposed routes that will expand entry into this qualification, allowing those with relevant shore-based or onboard experience to join the ETO programme. If you are interested in this route, please email exams@mcga.gov.uk for further guidance.

The specific timeline for each Alternative ETO route is detailed in Annex D.

More information

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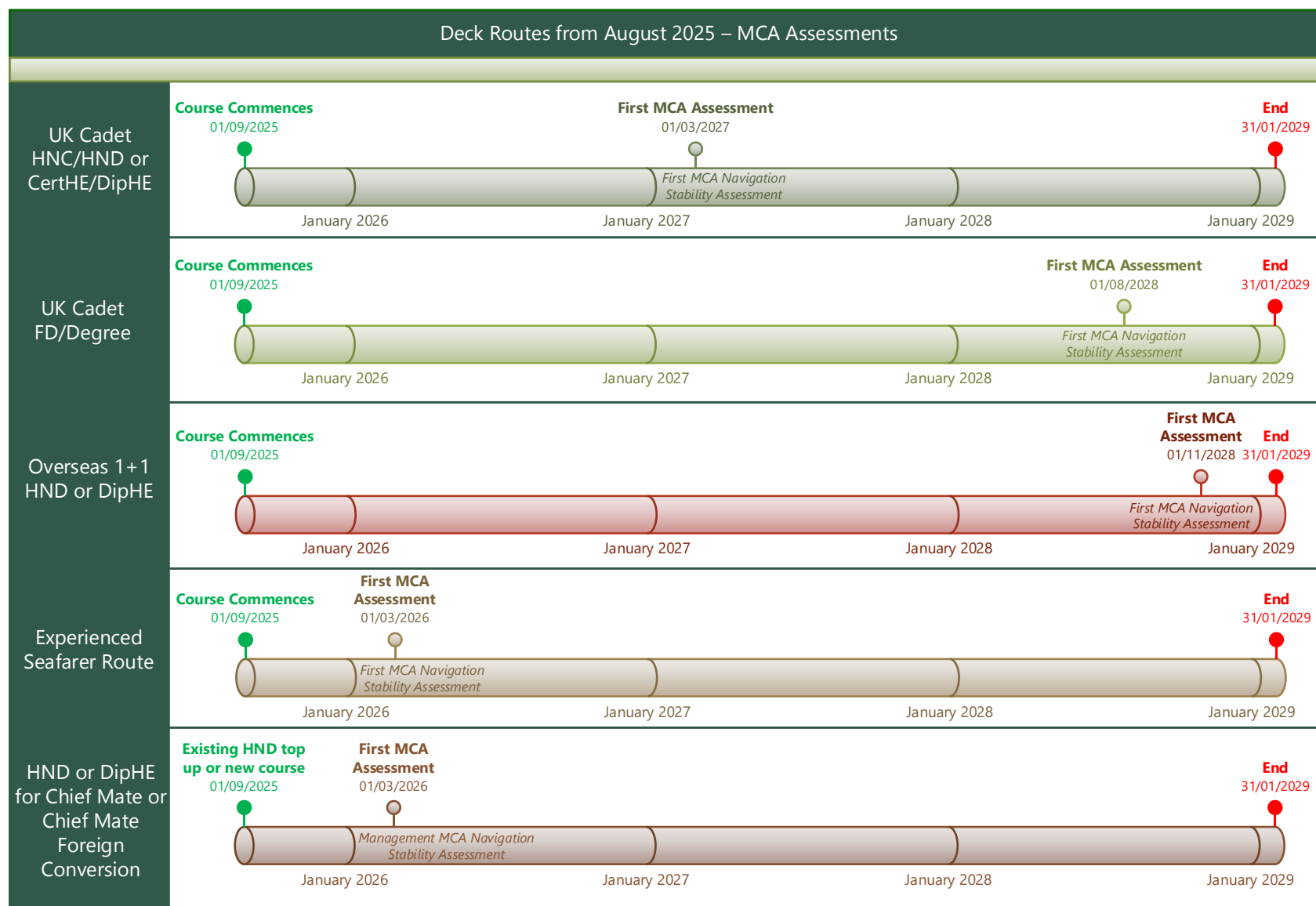
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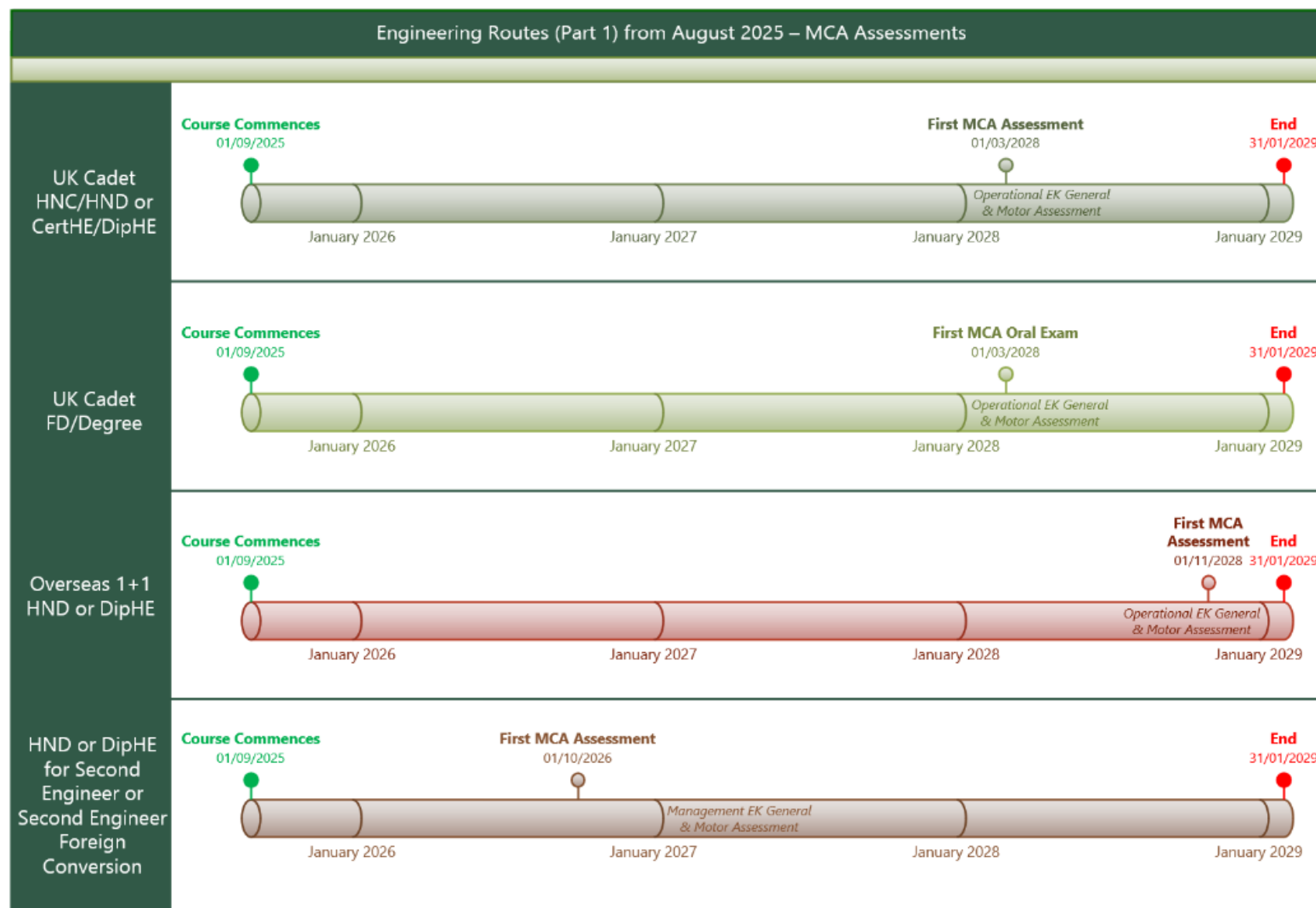
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Annex A

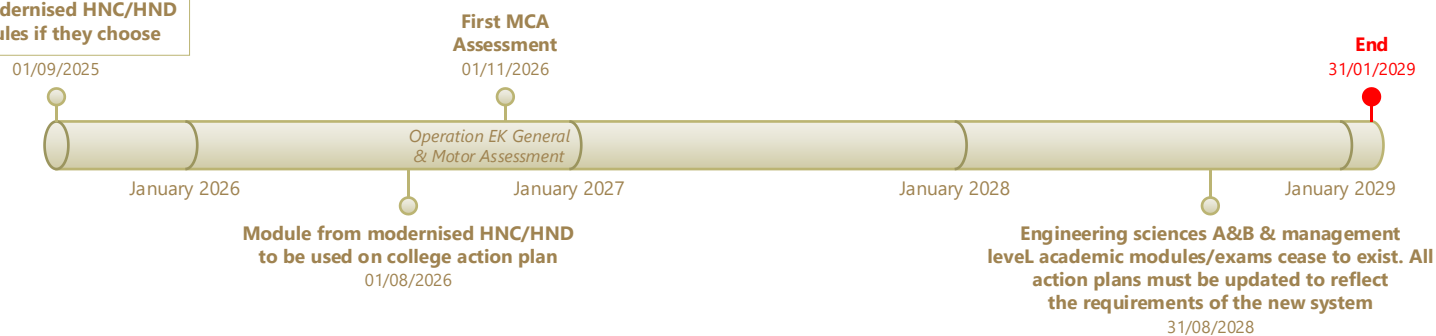




Engineering Routes (Part 2) from August 2025 – MCA Assessments

Alternate Route
College Action
Plan/Degree

Engineering sciences A&B
to continue on action plans
noting that colleges can use
the modernised HNC/HND
modules if they choose



Experienced
Seafarer Route

Engineering sciences A&B
to continue on action plans
noting that colleges can use
the modernised HNC/HND
modules if they choose



ETO Routes from August 2025 – MCA Assessments

UK Cadet FD/
HND/DipHE/
Degree



Experienced
Seafarer Route



LIA Fast Track
(Degree)

